

Course Report: SF2324 Introduction to Applied Research Design and Quantitative Research Methods for Social Scientists

Background and course Information

The course ran between November 2022 and January 2023. As in previous years the course is given by a team of teachers. Marina Nistotskaya and Georgios Xezonakis are the instructors for lectures while Mattias Agerberg, Jana Schwenk, Elena Leuschner and Luca Versteegen run the seminars. The latter two teachers were recruited this year and were a new addition to the team. Supervision and grading of the final papers was done by Nistotskaya, Xezonakis and Schwenk.

39 students were enrolled at the start of the course. This number is a bit lower from previous years as students from other department and master courses (e.g Criminology students) take this course every other year. We would expect this number to rise the following year. From those 39 currently 21 have finished the course. This completion of 53% is higher from previous years (on 2021 at this stage 46% had completed the course). This, among other things, can be attributed to a rule change whereby High Pass was not possible if the student submitted at a later date other than the official deadline.

11 achieved a high pass and 10 a pass. This is 52% of high passes is considerably lower compared to last year (69%). Currently, there is no clear reason for why that has been the case. There was no significant difference on marking between the three graders.

Student evaluation

The course survey was answer by 12 students, a response rate of 30%, as opposed to 50% last year. Regarding the course overall about 1 out of 3 students evaluate the course as 'Neither good nor bad' with about 66% registering a evaluation of 'fairly good' or higher. This is a similar evaluation as last year (3,9 vs 4.0 last year). Evaluation of the teachers is also similar as last year with a bit lower score (4.2 vs 4.5 last year). For the lectures, labs and the research design seminar evaluations are lower than last year. The labs have traditionally been the more highly evaluated aspects of the course however students seem to be more critical of them this year (4.4 average on a 5 point scale vs 3.5 average this year). Across the board student express more difficulty with lab assignments this year (with the exception of lab assignment 1). It is worth noting that the lab assignments have remained exactly the same as last year.

Students express more satisfaction this year for elements of the final paper (e.g the final paper itself and the final paper seminar). Evaluation of the literature is stable at 3.7 (5 point scale) and the same goes for effort (about 80% of the students spending 20-30 hours a week).

From the answers to the open-ended questions one think that stands out is suggestions about the first part of the course. This is a recurring theme since they do not find the research design part as helpful or at least they seem to be more eager to start with the methods and the use of STATA.

The full survey results are available via Maria Lilleste.

Conclusion

First it seems that some of the changes employed this year (e.g the change in grading for later papers) might have helped completion rates and should be kept for next year as well. Second, there is some concern regarding the overall evaluation of the course but also elements of it that traditionally students have found very helpful such as the labs. More emphasis needs to be put on those next year. Third there might time to rethink somewhat the first part of the course that emphasizes research design. We already started talking about this with the programme manager of IAGG Agnes Cornell. Any changes on that part would significantly impact lectures downstream so before any changes the course coordinator should consult with the other teachers and see whether this would require changes in the syllabus itself.